Claude Code — Guide for Non-Programmers (Basics)

A practical guide to getting things done with Claude Code, even if you've never written code before.

> ***Disclaimer:*** *I have no business relationship with any of the tools or services mentioned in this guide. These are personal recommendations based on my experience. Use them at your own discretion — I take no responsibility for any outcomes.*

TL;DR

Most people experience AI as copy-pasting from ChatGPT. That's fine most of the time but for large projects it can be frustrating.

Today with AI agents and specifically Claude you can work much more efficiently:

- Claude runs on your computer and can view and edit your files.
- You can give Claude context of your work and specific instructions on how it should be done.
- With some technical background you can make it create whatever you want - documents, presentations, websites, etc.

That is a very powerful tool.

I wrote this guide because I think many people that don't work in code can also benefit from AI much more then they are used too.

Demos

- Presentations - were created using a simple prompt, can be opened using a web browser
- Document - PDF version of this guide, was created using the following command:

```
python markdown_to_pdf.py 1-basics.md -o demos/basics.pdf
```

Getting Started — What to Install

To follow this guide you need three things installed on your computer:

1. **VS Code** (free) — a text editor where you'll do all your work. Download from code.visualstudio.com. Just run the installer and open it.
2. **Python** (free) — a programming language that Claude uses behind the scenes to perform powerful actions. Download from python.org/downloads. During installation, make sure to check **"Add Python to PATH"**. You can verify it works by opening a terminal and typing `python --version`.
3. **Claude Code** (~20$) — the AI assistant itself. Install the Claude Code extension in VS Code: open VS Code → click the Extensions icon in the left sidebar (`Ctrl+Shift+X`) → search "Claude Code" → click Install. You'll need an Anthropic account to use it.

Learning

This guide introduces you to some basic terms and technologies.

You want to know more? - Google it or ask your favorite LLM :)

Today you can learn and do anything - you are limited only by your imagination.

Short Technical Background

Here are some terms that will help you get the most of Claude.

Files

Your computer contains many files - pictures, documents, programs...

The most basic file is a text file - it can contains only characters.

You should know that every text file has an encoding which means how to read it. For english and standard symbols use "ASCII", for more languages use "UTF-8".

Python

Python is a programming language. You don't need to learn it or understand it — just know that Claude can use Python behind the scenes to perform powerful actions for you, like processing data, converting files, or automating tasks. When Claude needs Python, it will handle everything automatically.

VS Code

What is it?

VS Code (Visual Studio Code) is a free text editor by Microsoft. Think of it as a supercharged Notepad — it can open any file, color-code different languages, and run tools like Claude Code inside it.

Installation

Download from code.visualstudio.com

Key concepts

- **File Explorer** (left sidebar) — browse and open files in your project folder
- **Editor** (center) — where you view and edit files
- **Terminal** (bottom panel) — a command line built into VS Code
- **Extensions** (left sidebar, block icon) — add-ons (plugins) that give VS Code new abilities (like Claude Code, Python support, etc.)
- **Command Palette** — press `Ctrl+Shift+P` to search for any action

Installing extensions

Extensions add features to VS Code — language support, themes, tools, and more. To install:

1. Click the **Extensions** icon in the left sidebar (or `Ctrl+Shift+X`)
2. Search for what you need
3. Click **Install**

How to pick safe extensions:

- **Prefer verified publishers** — look for the blue checkmark next to the publisher name. These are verified by Microsoft.
- **If not verified** — check the download count and ratings. Popular extensions (millions of downloads, 4+ stars) are generally safe.
- **Be careful** with unknown extensions that have few downloads — they could contain bugs or even malicious code. When in doubt, search online for recommendations.

Essential shortcuts

Action	Shortcut
Open Command Palette	`Ctrl+Shift+P`
Open file by name	`Ctrl+P`
Toggle terminal	`Ctrl+``
Toggle sidebar	`Ctrl+B`
Save file	`Ctrl+S`
Find in file	`Ctrl+F`
Find in all files	`Ctrl+Shift+F`
Open Simple Browser (sidebar preview)	`Ctrl+Shift+P` → type "Simple Browser"

> ***Further reading:*** *VS Code Getting Started*

Markdown

What is it?

Markdown is a simple way to format text using plain characters. Files end in `.md`. This guide is written in Markdown.

Syntax

```
# Heading 1
## Heading 2
### Heading 3

**bold text**
*italic text*

- bullet point
- another bullet

1. numbered list
2. second item
```

```
[link text](https://example.com)

> blockquote

`inline code`
```

How to preview

- In VS Code: open a `.md` file → `Ctrl+Shift+V` to preview, or `Ctrl+K V` to preview side-by-side
- You can ask Claude to create Markdown files and preview them directly in VS Code

> ***Further reading:*** *Markdown Guide*

Creating PDF from markdown files

There is a helper script called `markdown_to_pdf.py` that converts Markdown files to PDF. To use it:

1. Copy the file `markdown_to_pdf.py` into your project folder
2. Ask Claude: "Convert my-document.md to PDF using markdown_to_pdf.py"

Claude will install the required dependencies and run the script for you.

Claude Code

What is it?

Claude Code is an AI assistant that lives inside VS Code (or the terminal). It can read, create, and edit files on your computer. You talk to it in plain language and it does the work.

Where can it be used?

- Any terminal - run `claude`
- VSCode - Install plugin, `CTRL+SHIFT+P -> "Claude code: Open in Side Bar"`

What can it do?

- **Edit files** — "change the heading color to red" or "fix the typo in paragraph 3"
- **Create files** — "create a document with sections for date, attendees, and action items" or "make a website with a contact form"

- **Explain things** — "what does this file do?"
- **Run commands** — it can run terminal commands on your behalf (like converting files, processing data, etc.)

Can I create an app using Claude?

- **Website** — can be created very easily, but it will exist only on your computer.
    - If you want it to be accessible to others you need to host it somewhere.
    - If you want it to have a database and interact with other internet services — also possible but a bit more complicated.
- **Phone App** — not directly. Building a native phone app requires developer accounts (Apple/Google), specific tools, and a more complex setup. However, Claude can help you create a **web app** that works well on phones — it looks and feels like an app when opened in a mobile browser, and is much simpler to build and share.

CLAUDE.md — giving Claude context

You can create a file called `CLAUDE.md` in your project folder to give Claude context and instructions. Claude reads this file automatically when it starts. Use it to describe your project and how Claude should work in it. For example:

```
This is a marketing project. All documents should be in Hebrew.
Output files go in the "output" folder.
```

Modes

Mode	What it can do	When to use
Plan mode	Reads files, thinks, makes a plan	When you want to review before changes
Normal mode	Reads and edits files	Day-to-day work

Permissions

Claude asks for permission before doing things like editing files or running commands. You can:

- **Allow once** — approve this single action
- **Allow for this project** — clicking "Yes, don't ask again" saves the permission for the current project folder. This means Claude won't ask again for the same type of action in this project, but will still ask in other projects.

> ***Recommended for beginners:*** *approve each action individually ("Allow once") until you're comfortable with what Claude does. This way you stay in control and can review every change.*

Things to try

Create Markdown documents:

> *"Create a markdown file called meeting-notes.md with sections for date, attendees, agenda, and action items"*

Build websites:

> *"Create a simple website with a dark theme that shows a list of my favorite books. Make it look nice."*

Create presentations:

> *Have text material you want to present? Ask Claude to turn it into a web-based slideshow. For example: "Create an HTML presentation from this text" — then open the* `.html` *file in your browser. It's a quick way to make good-looking slides without PowerPoint.*

Convert to PDF:

> *"Convert my-document.md to PDF using markdown_to_pdf.py"*

Preview in VS Code sidebar:

> *After creating an HTML file, open it in VS Code's Simple Browser:* `Ctrl+Shift+P` → *"Simple Browser: Show"* → *enter the file path*

Edit existing files:

> *"In index.html, change the background color to light gray and make the font bigger"*

Tips

- Be specific about what you want — "make the title blue and centered" works better than "make it

look better"

- You can select text in VS Code and ask Claude about just that selection
- If Claude's change isn't what you wanted, just tell it — "undo that" or "no, I meant the other heading"
- Claude can work with any file type — text, code, config files, etc.

What's Next?

Ready to go further? The advanced guide covers:

- **Git & GitHub** — save your work, track changes, and display it publicly from any computer or phone
- **Command Line** — understand how your computer runs processes under the hood
- **Python** — create more complex and powerful operations with Claude